



▼ Women's work

In some European countries, women were employed in the mining industry until the late 19th century. Here, women load coal in Hainaut, Belgium, 1873.

moved to factories, where working-class men earned very low wages, women and children joined the workforce in order to help support their families. Women were largely excluded from burgeoning sectors of the economy such as mining, heavy industry, and transportation, notably the railways. The vast majority of female workers were crowded into a small number of occupations, particularly textile and clothing manufacturing, domestic service, and farming.

The 19th century saw the rise in influence of the notion of “separate spheres,” according to which the ideal place for women was the

“domestic sphere,” meaning life as a wife and mother. Middle-class men's wages rose during the Industrial Revolution; this meant that, in some cases, a husband could earn enough that his wife did not need to take on paid work outside the home. Middle-class married women were increasingly expected to oversee the management of the household rather than go out to work. For many women, therefore, the Industrial Revolution actually altered their economic and public roles. However, among the working class—roughly two-thirds of the population—women had little choice but to work outside the home.

